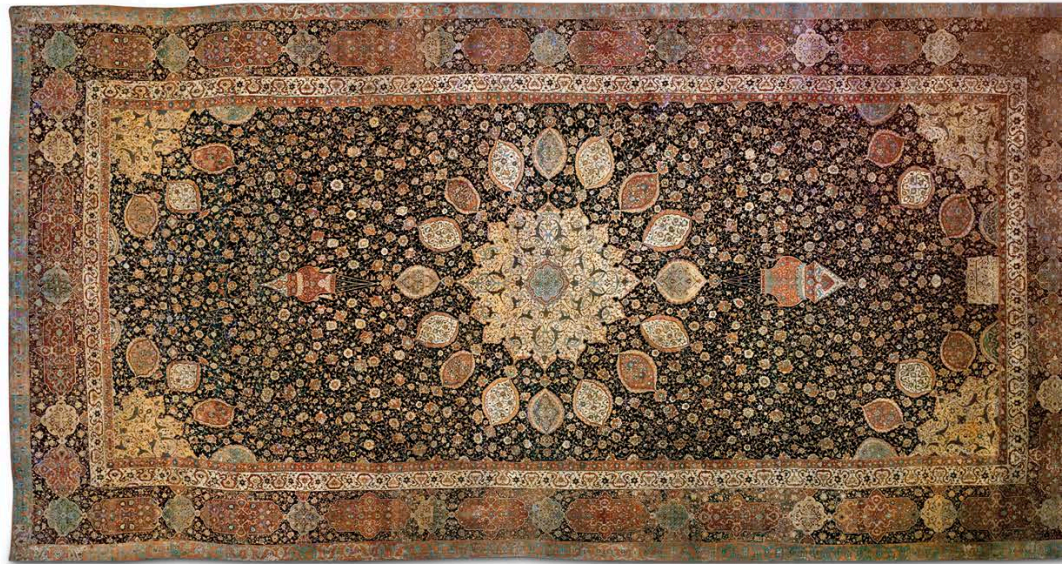




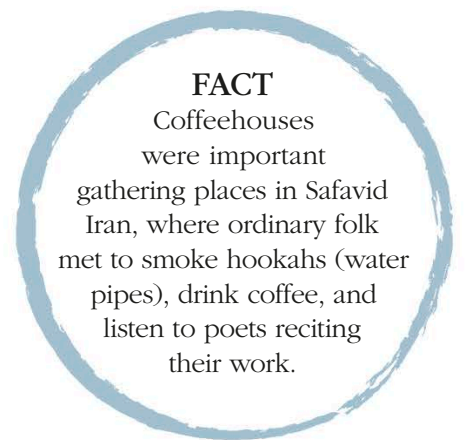
▲ THE SHAHNAMEA

Safavid artists produced some of the finest illuminated manuscripts of the period. These hand-decorated books often contained detailed paintings of scenes from folk or historical stories. Tales from the Shahnama (Book of Kings), an epic poem by the 10th-century Persian poet Ferdowsi, were very popular. The illustrations for these stories linked the Safavid shahs to ancient Persian rulers to make them appear as heroes.



▲ PERSIAN RUGS

During the Safavid period, carpet weaving expanded to become an important industry. Carpets woven from silk and gold contained a combination of flower and geometric patterns. They were exported to markets all over Europe, and even as far as China.



FACT

Coffeehouses were important gathering places in Safavid Iran, where ordinary folk met to smoke hookahs (water pipes), drink coffee, and listen to poets reciting their work.

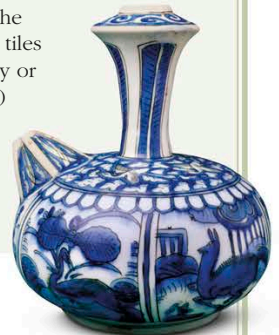


Metal decorated with gold

GOLD AND METAL JUG

ART AND CRAFTS

Safavid arts and crafts were inspired by the work of the Ottomans and the Chinese. The most well known are tiles decorated with beautiful calligraphy or using the *haft-rangi* ("seven-color") technique. Also popular were Chinese-inspired blue and white ceramics, woven carpets, and intricate metalwork.



CERAMIC DRINKING VESSEL



CALLIGRAPHY ON THE MASJID-E-SHAH, ISFAHAN



GLAZED DECORATIVE TILE



Honeycomb-like ceiling design